

Drops: creator links that stop burying your friends

Creators run comment-to-DM automations. The link lands in the same inbox as your friends, so the link gets buried and so does your friend's chat. **Drops** keeps every DM where it is, takes automated DMs out of the main list, and opens them into a library of the reels and posts you commented on. It also skips the Requests step.

What's in here

- Before: a real creator interaction, the Requests step, then today's flooded inbox
- After: friends first, Drops, requests that skip Accept, the resource sheet
- Waiting rows, delivery rules and noise
- The later version: search, topics, aliases and lists
- Decisions we made and options we left for later
- Assumptions and metrics

About the screens

Captured from a clickable prototype on an iPhone 17 frame that borrows Instagram's look so the flow feels real. It is a concept, not Instagram's UI, and nothing here detects links from real messages. Handles and people are invented.

Scope Proposed, to confirm

V1. The core fix, and it has to be trustworthy: friends first with the floating banner, Drops home (Waiting on you, Waiting for link, Pinned, Recent), requests that land in Waiting on you, one follow check, the resource sheet with a one-line summary and a Pin icon, the in-app browser, every delivery pattern, and noise tucked away.

Later version

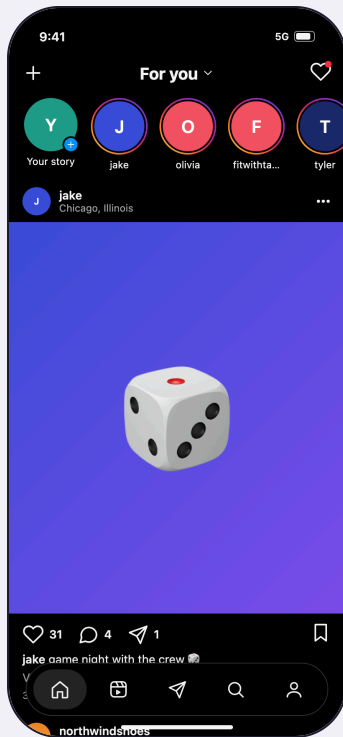
The double-tap pin gesture, search by memory with recent searches, topic rows with See all and Customize topics, aliases and your own lists, Creators you engaged with and creator pages, and Recent cards grouped by creator.

Why this split: V1 fixes the two problems, friends buried and links lost. The later version helps finding things once the library grows.

How a real creator interaction goes

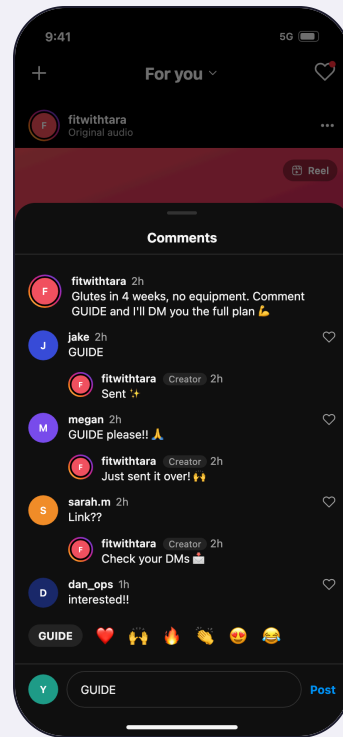
Before 1 of 2

Modelled on a real comment-to-DM automation. You comment, the creator replies in public, and a DM arrives with a red number.



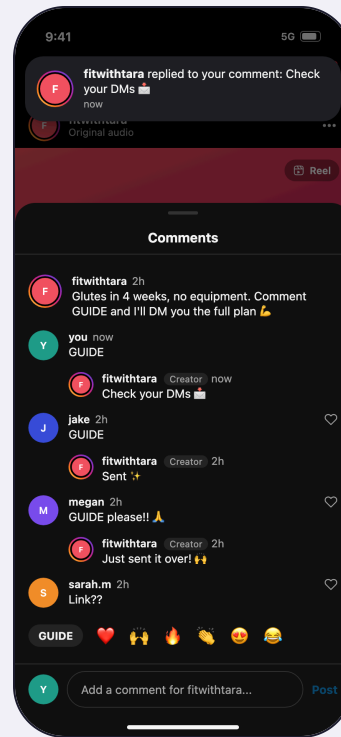
1 Feed

The reel sits among friends' posts and stories.



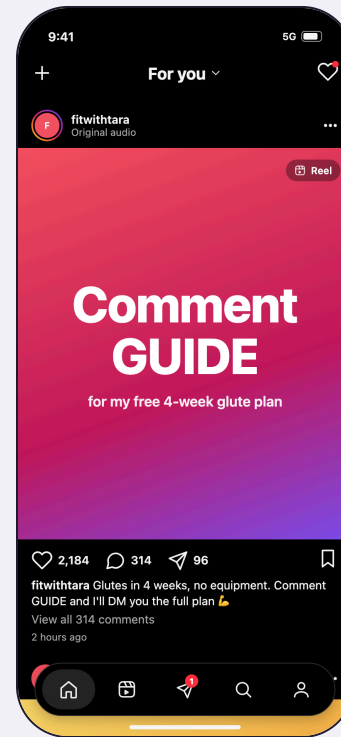
2 You comment

You type the keyword and tap Post. Others have already commented the same.



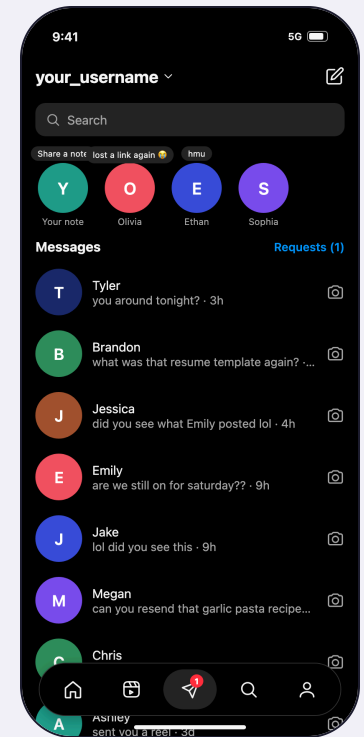
3 Public reply

The creator replies under your comment, then a notification. Reply wording varies.



4 Red number

The DM tab shows a red 1 after the DM arrives.



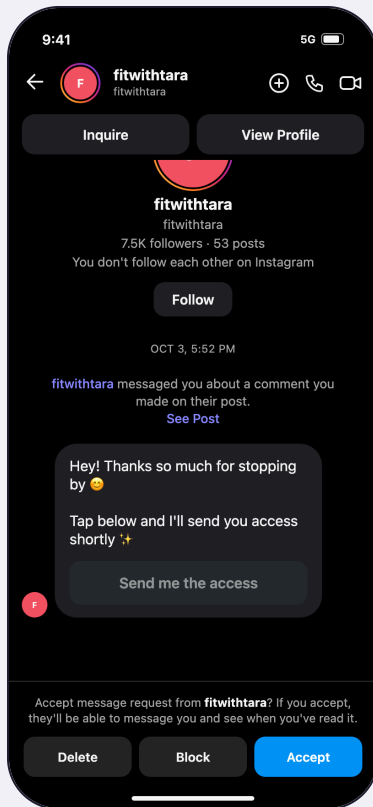
5 A request waits

You do not follow the creator yet, so the DM is not in the main list. "Requests (1)" sits at the top right.

How a real creator interaction goes

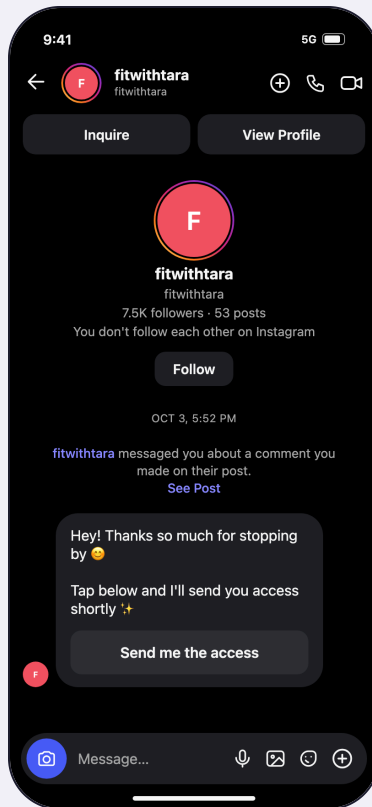
Before 2 of 2

You open the request and accept it. Only then does the creator's chat join your inbox, and every response still comes from your side.



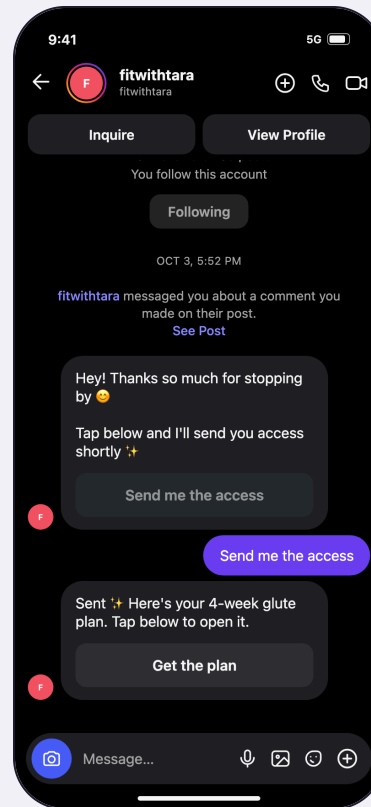
6 The request opens

Accept, Delete or Block. The creator's button waits behind it.



7 Accept

The thread moves into your inbox. You tap for access and the creator follows up.



8 Link delivered

The delivered message has an opener, text and a button.

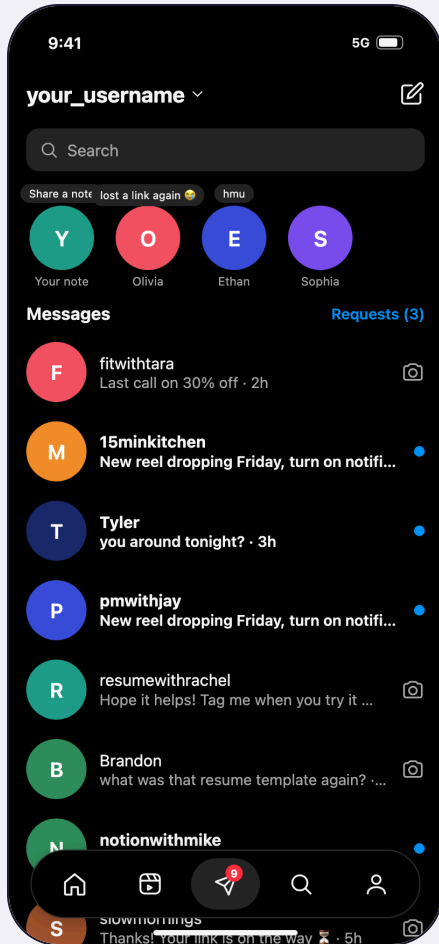
What to notice

- Accepting is a step with no decision in it. You asked for the link, so you accept.
- You always answer first. A button tap, a keyword, a follow or a typed reply shows as a purple message from you.
- "Sent" is not a separate message. It sits in the delivered text, or in the comment reply.
- Follow-ups and promos arrive after the link and bury it over the following weeks.

Before: weeks later, the inbox is flooded

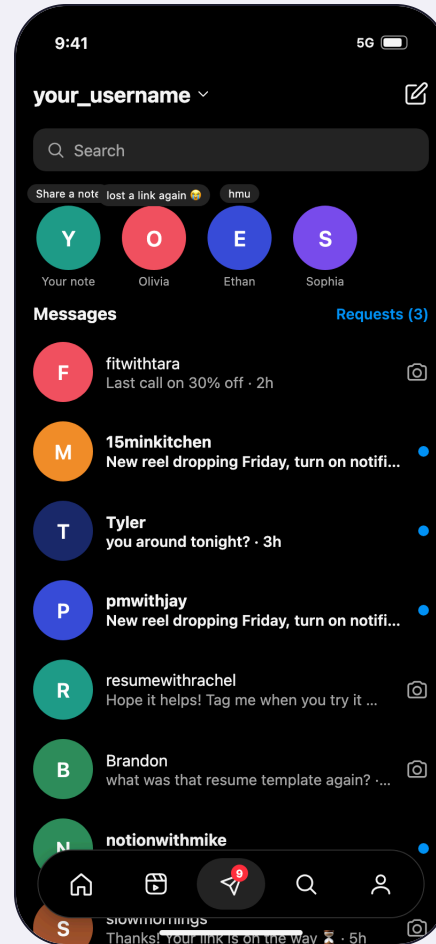
Before

Creator threads and their follow-ups take over the inbox. Friends and links both get lost.



Flooded inbox

22 threads and 3 more requests. Unread friends sit between creator threads. The thread where the link arrived looks read.



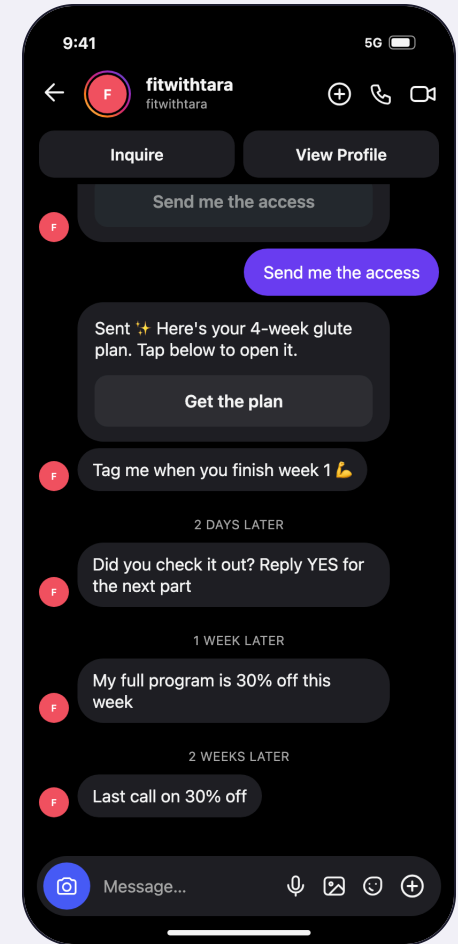
A friend is buried

Emily's unread message sits far down, under creator promos.



Search finds nothing

Messages search matches names and accounts. "pasta" returns no results.

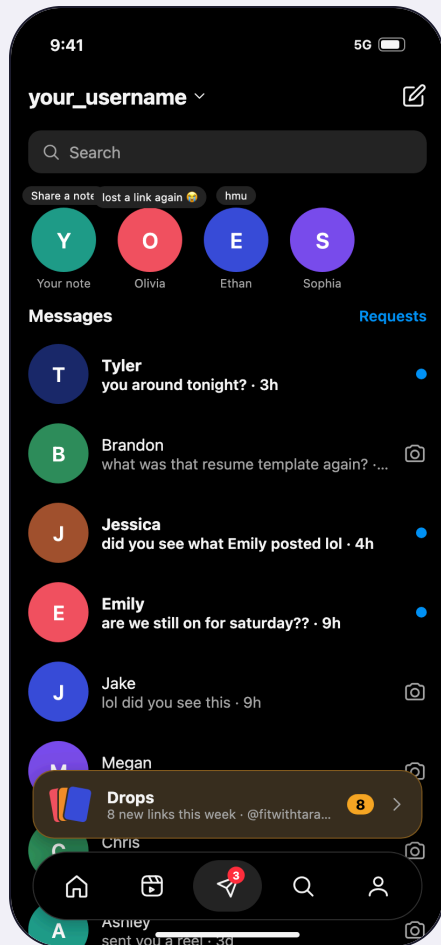


Scrolling for the link

The link sits far above the follow-ups and promos.

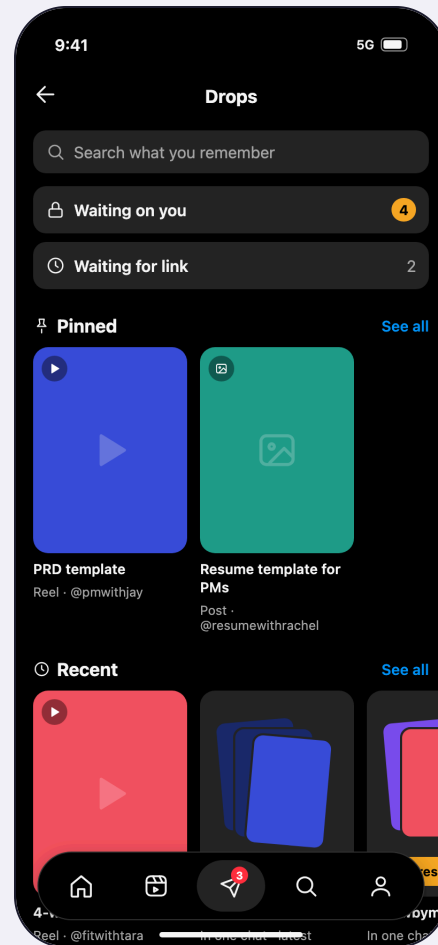
After: friends first, links in Drops V1

Same DMs, nothing deleted. Automated DMs leave the main list and open into a library of what you asked for.



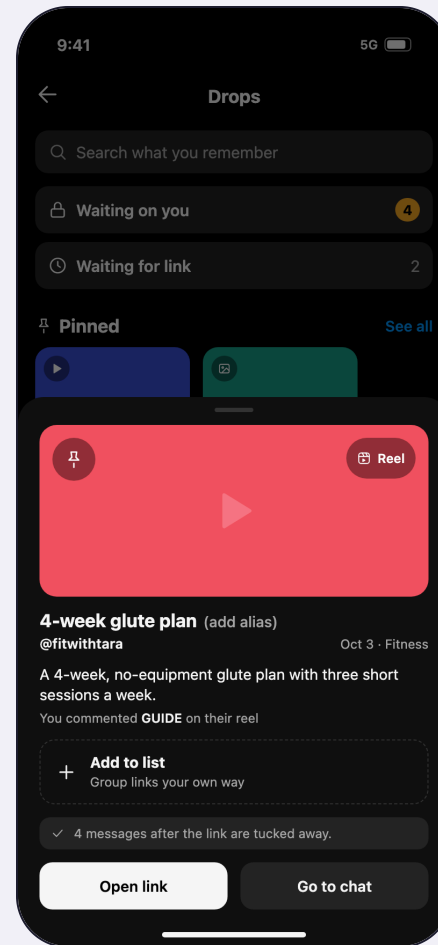
Friends first

Only friends in the list. The red number counts friends only. A floating banner above the tab bar opens Drops.



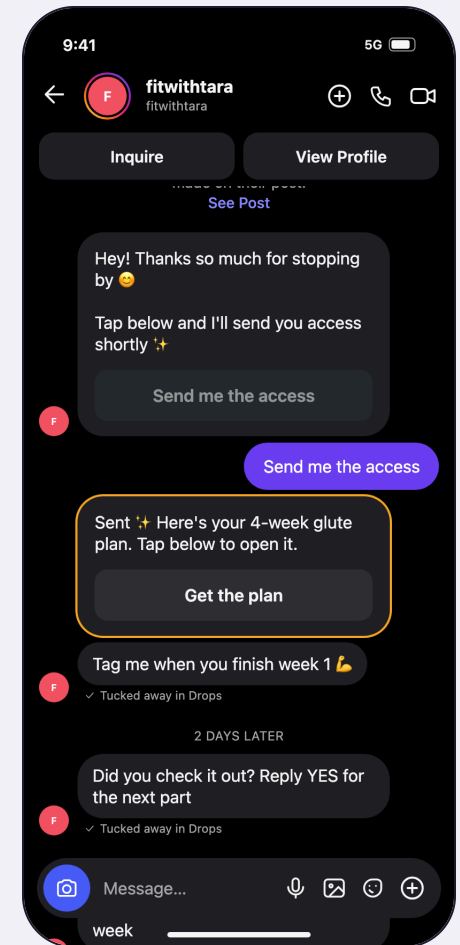
Drops

Waiting on you and Waiting for link on top, then Pinned and Recent. Rows scroll sideways.



Resource sheet

A one-line summary, the creator once, the date as small text, Open link, Go to chat and a Pin icon.



Go to chat

Opens the thread with the delivered message highlighted. Messages after the link are marked as tucked away.

After: requests skip Accept, and the Waiting rows

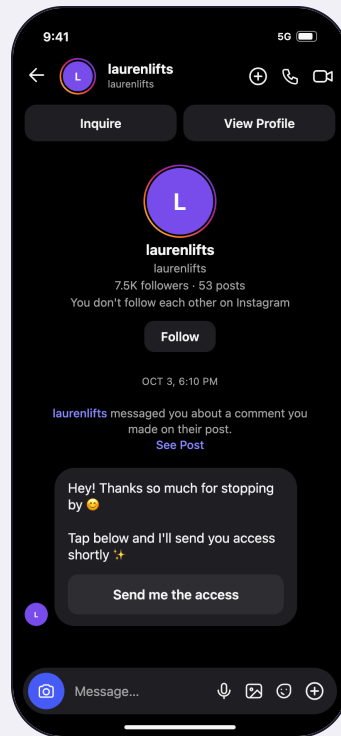
V1

A request from a creator you do not follow shows up in Waiting on you. No Accept step, no Requests tab. Anything that needs you or the creator is visible.



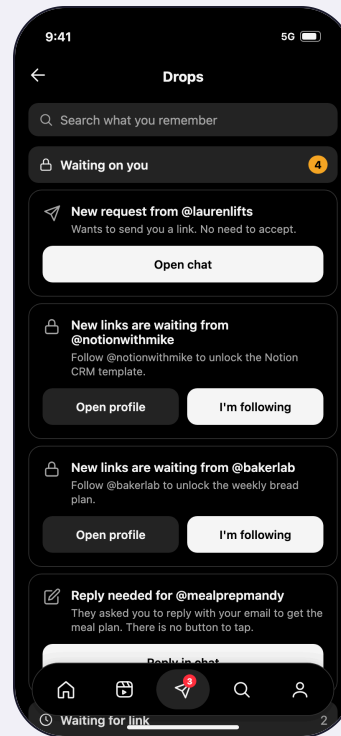
Search finds it

"that pasta thing" matches what the reel was about, not just names. (Search is later version.)



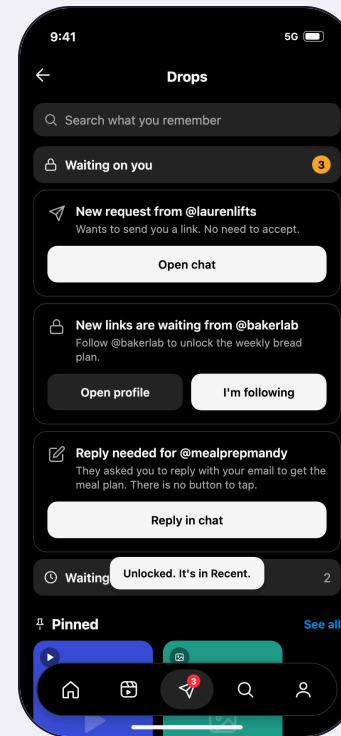
Request, no accept

"Wants to send you a link. No need to accept." Open chat is the one action.



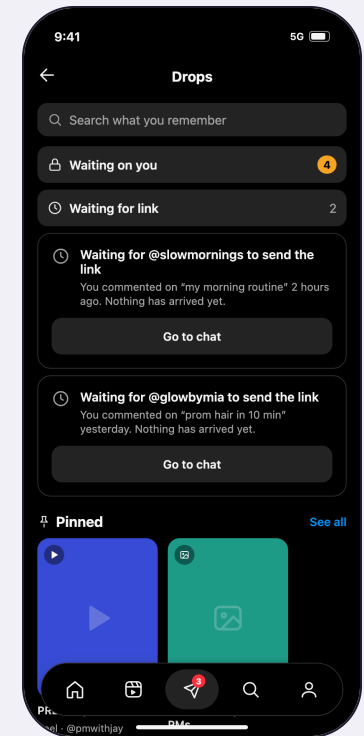
Waiting on you

Open profile, then I'm following. One check only: the button looks at your follow state.



Unlocked

After you follow and tap, the card moves into Recent with a toast.



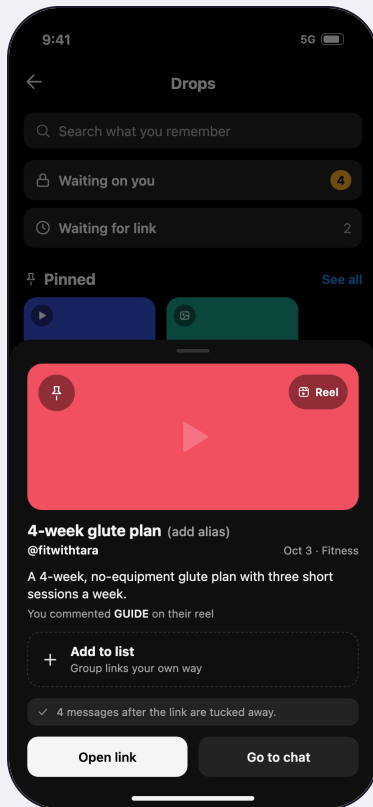
Waiting for link

You commented and nothing has arrived. Go to chat shows the acknowledgement.

The resource sheet: one line of context

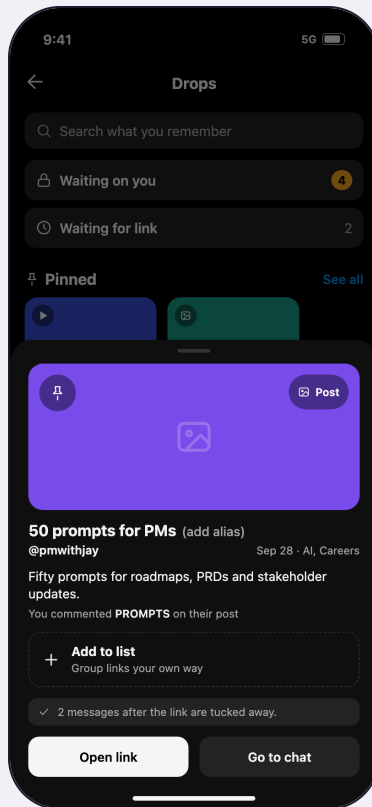
v1

Captions and DMs can be long. The sheet leaves out the dialogue and gives you a single summary line, so you remember why you saved it.



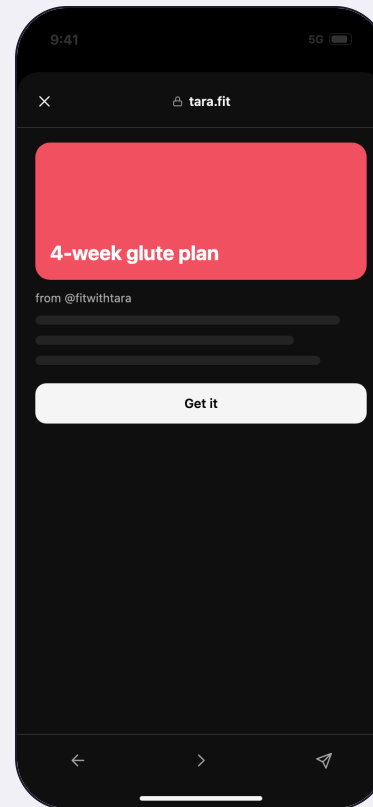
Summary, not dialogue

"A 4-week, no-equipment glute plan." Then a grey "You commented GUIDE on their reel."



Alias and lists

A greyed "add alias" next to the title. Add to list is a quiet row.



Open link

Opens an in-app browser mock. Close returns to the sheet.

Rules

- The creator is named once. The date is small text. An alias sits in brackets and never replaces the original title.
- One summary line per link, written once when the link is delivered, from the caption and the creator's message. About \$0.0006 a link with a small text model, and cached. Text only: no audio transcripts.
- It reverses an earlier cut of "AI summary". The risk is a wrong summary, so the line stays close to the creator's own words and the alias is your override.
- Search still reads the full caption and message, even though the sheet hides them.

How a link counts as delivered V1

Decide by deliverable, not button type. This replaces the first draft's "first outside link" rule.

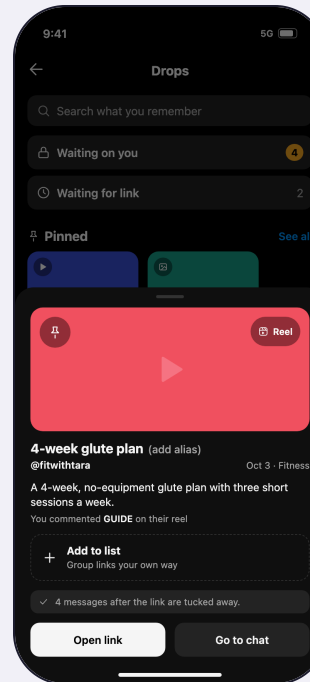
The rule

A sequence starts at the private reply to your comment. We scan that creator's later messages for a deliverable: a URL button, a URL in the message text, or a file or media attachment. instagram.com links never count.

- **Deliverable found:** Delivered.
- **None yet, and the latest message waits on a tap or a typed reply:** Waiting on you.
- **You did your part and nothing has arrived:** Waiting for link.

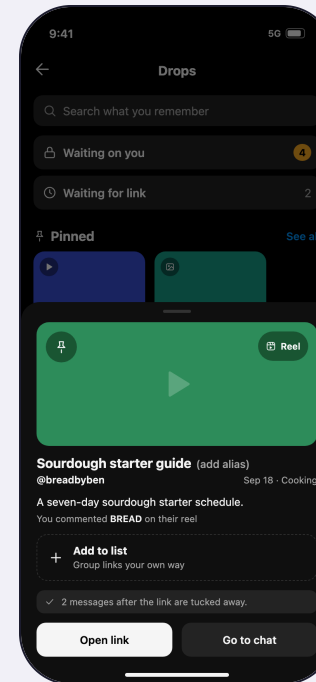
Cases

- **Link in a button** counts, and tapping it opens the link.
- **Link in the text** is picked up and shown as a link.
- **A message with a link per bullet** is the resource. It opens in full.
- **A prompt after delivery** ("Reply YES for the next part") is noise, not a gate.
- Later checkout links stay in the thread. Linked files behind a login are never read.
- Links show their domain only. We do not expand shortened links.



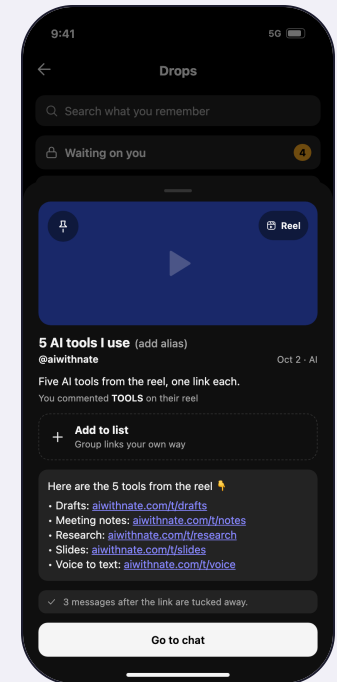
In a button

"Link from the creator's button." Open link goes to the page.



In the text

Picked up and tappable.



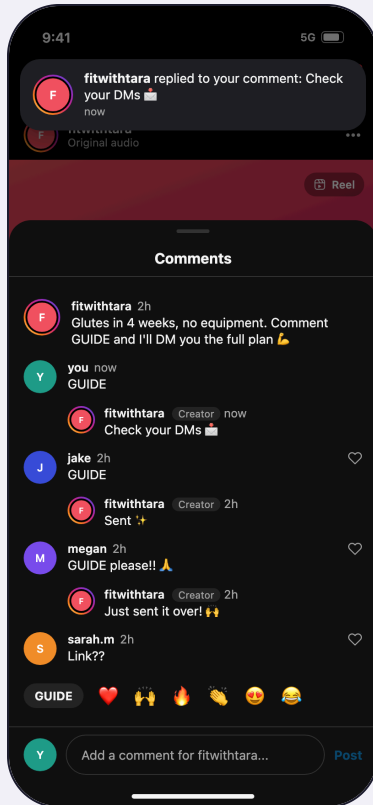
Link per bullet

Shown in full.

Noise is tucked away, not deleted

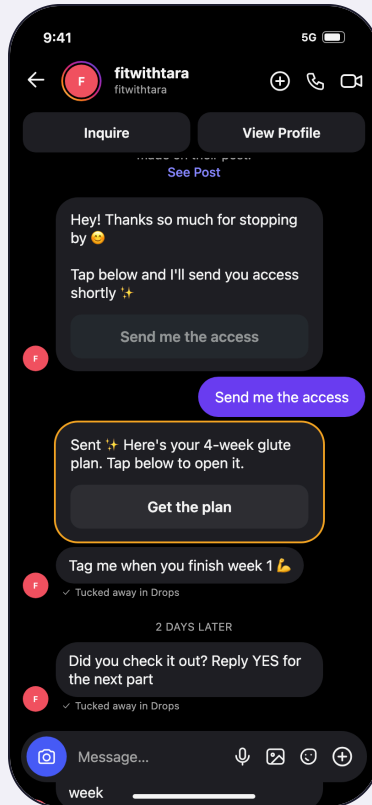
V1

Drops tucks away what a creator sends after your link arrives. Comments and their replies are left alone.



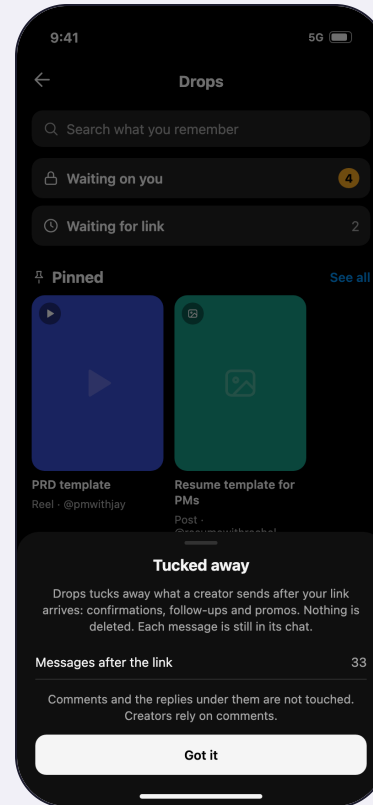
Comments stay put

Creators' public replies stay in the comments, where creators count engagement.



Marked in the chat

Messages after the link carry a small "Tucked away" note.



Counted

One category, with the total.

What gets tucked away

- Confirmations, follow-ups and promos a creator sends after the link.
- Defined by position, not by wording, because creators write their own replies.

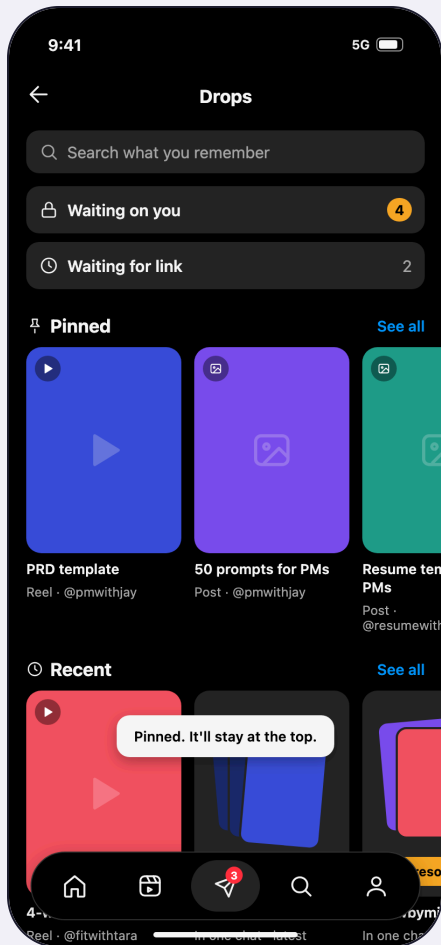
What does not

- Public replies and notifications under your comments.
- Anything before the link is delivered.
- Your own messages and button taps.

Later version: pin, search and topics

Later version

Ways to find things once the library grows. The Pin icon on the resource sheet is V1. The gesture and the rest come later.



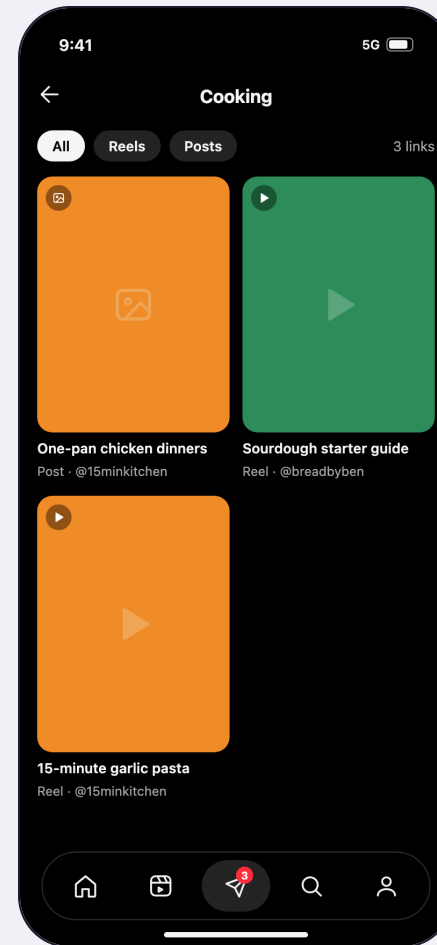
Double-tap to pin

Pinned items move to the top row.



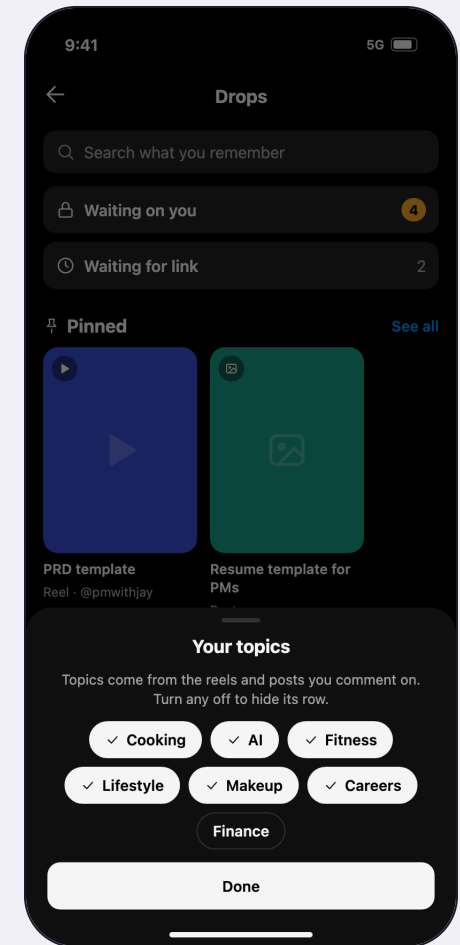
Recent searches

"that pasta thing" is a recent search you can delete.



See all

Reels and posts, with All, Reels and Posts filters.



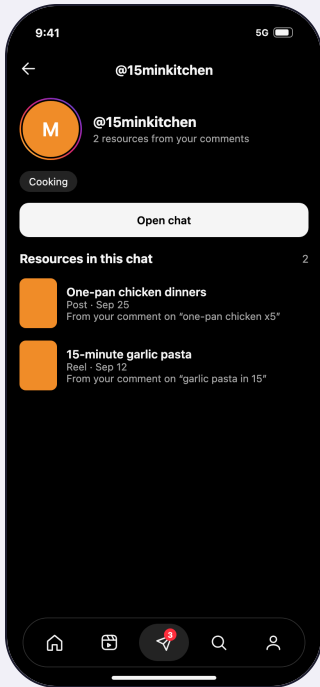
Customize topics

Topics come from what you comment on. Turn any off.

Later version: creators, aliases and lists

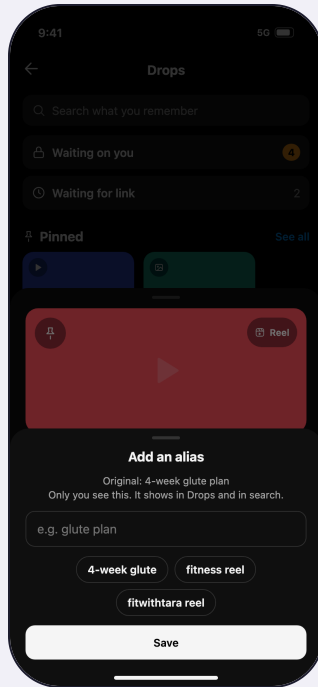
Later version

One creator can send many links, and a handle can be just a name. Browse by creator, add an alias to one link, and group links your own way.



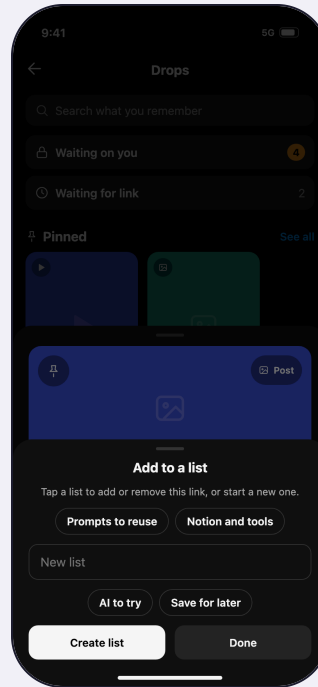
Creator page

Their chat and every resource, each tied to the comment that triggered it.



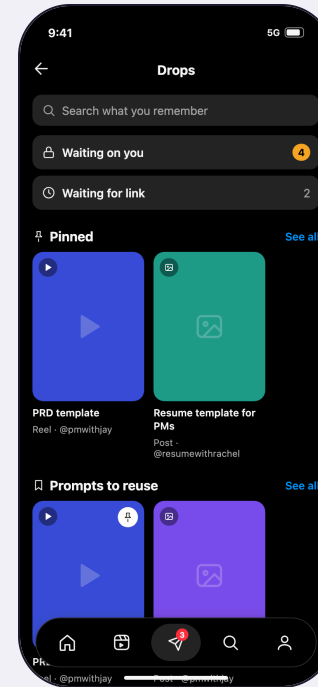
Add an alias

A greyed prompt next to the title. One-tap suggestions. Only you see it.



Add to list

Pick a list or start one. Once lists exist, the control shrinks to a small chip.



Your lists

Lists sit under Pinned on the Drops home.

Why no creator labels, and no nesting

- Creators' reach and engagement are the point for Instagram, and creator names are not ours to customize.
- An alias on one link is enough to find "that pasta thing."
- Lists are flat and yours. No topic hierarchy to maintain.

Decisions and options we left for later

The rule we used: keep a feature if it is low effort or high value, and drop it if it is mid-to-high effort for low value.

ITEM	EFFORT	VALUE	CALL	WHY
Red number on the DM tab, unread thread first	Low	High	Keep	Makes the story feel real and shows the badge inflation problem.
Requests step before the chat	Low	High	Remove	Before keeps it. After puts the request in Waiting on you, with no Accept.
In-chat follow gate that repeats	Mid	Low	Remove	Frictional and redundant. One "I'm following" check, no counter, so it cannot be mashed.
Waiting on you, Waiting for link	Low	High	Keep	Separates "you need to act" from "the creator has not sent."
One-line summary per link	Low-mid	High	Keep	About \$0.0006 a link, text only. Replaces the clipped caption and the dialogue. Reverses the earlier "AI summary" cut.
In-app browser on Open link	Low	High	Keep	A link button that shows nothing feels broken. Instagram already opens its own browser.
Expanding shortened links	Mid-high	Low	Drop	Instagram already checks links. We show the domain only.
Creator labels, nested topic lists	Mid	Low	Drop	Tags already cover creators. Flat lists and one alias are enough.
Aliases and lists	Low-mid	Mid	Later	Useful once the library grows. A quieter control once lists exist.
Forward a resource to a friend	Low-mid	Low-mid	Later	If built, forward the reel or post only, so the friend triggers their own DM and the creator keeps the engagement.

Assumptions and metrics

What this concept depends on, and how I would measure it. Metrics are proposals with no data behind them yet.

Assumptions

- Automated DMs are identifiable because tools like ManyChat send through the Messaging API. Meta's docs show an echo flag on app-sent messages.
- The first DM is a Private Reply tied to the comment. The docs allow one message per comment, within 7 days.
- Later messages in the sequence are tied to the comment by time window, not by ID. Two comments on two posts by one creator the same day are ambiguous.
- Button URLs are readable as structured data. The docs show URL buttons carry a type, url and title.
- Follow state is checkable. The user profile API exposes whether the user follows the account.
- Reel captions are available. Linked files behind a login are never read.

Not confirmed

- Which attachment types Instagram DMs allow from automations.
- Whether a private reply's first message can carry a button template.
- How encrypted chats or data exports treat these messages.
- That DM search matches names and accounts only, as shown in Before.
- Whether Instagram would fire the creator's "I'm following" tap for you.
- Whether a request can be shown in Drops without accepting it, given spam and safety rules for non-followers.
- Feasibility: Instagram itself can build this. A third-party app only sees messages for creator accounts that connect it.

Proposed metrics

- Taps to open a friend's chat for heavy commenters, before vs. after.
- 7-day revisit rate on resources delivered by automation.
- Comment-to-DM participation per user over 90 days, to check that a cleaner inbox does not reduce commenting.
- Share of resources opened after day 7.
- Time to find a resource by search, and searches that end in an opened resource (later version).
- Share of resources pinned, aliased or added to a list (later version).

Open questions

- How reliably can gated messages be told apart from delivered ones across automation tools?
- Does a button tap weeks later still return the link from every tool?
- How long does a sequence stay open before we call it Waiting for link?
- Do data exports keep button URLs? A cheap test: run a comment-to-DM flow with a URL button on a test account, then check the export.
- Where does the first draft's "Older after 30 days" group live in the new layout?